

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 6
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Justice, Mercy, Humility
12 July 2026

COMMUNION

Preaching: ML

Worship Leading: Rev. Michael Schiefelbein & LVF

Guest Organist: Dr. Jaebon Hwang

Organ Prelude-Concert

Fanfare, Kenneth Leighton (1929-1988)
A Song of Sunshine, Alfred Hollins (1865-1942)
Aria, Paul Manz (1919-2009)
All Praise to Thee, My God, This Night, arr. Paul Manz
Fiesta, Emma Lou Diemer (1927-2024)
Roulade, Seth Bingham (1882-1972)
Processional, William Mathias (1934-1992)

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

[Jaebon, reminder to make sure you see pastors before starting to ring the chimes. They'll be across from you in the side doorway]

Chiming of the Hour

[LVF & MS to center chancel]

Welcome

LVF

Words of Gathering

MS & LVF

MS: So much has been hidden:
To protect narratives and people.
To disempower.
To confuse.

LVF: Unsatisfied with stories that get us by
but never get us free,
may we be people who search beyond,
who listen beneath,
who feel through and through.

MS: Though we know only in part,
we do not grow weary in faith.
Though the chaos of injustice shrouds our view,
with each new learning and unlearning
the partial fades away.

LVF: The histories
and complicities
and losses
and power
of our entangled lives
cry out for understanding.

*With courage, we open ourselves to truth.
With humility, we endeavor to be transformed.
With hope, we hold on to each other.*

MS: May Love lead us in the sacred work of unveiling.

LVF: May all that shrouds justice be uncovered
and the ways of healing mercy revealed.
[Rev. M Jade Kaiser, *enfleshed*]

MS: May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

LVF: *Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Jaebon reminder to keep the hymns crisp.

***Hymn Of Gathering**

In the Midst of New Dimensions

NEW DIMENSIONS

[PDF](#)

In the midst of new dimensions, in the face of changing ways.
Who will lead the pilgrim peoples wandering in their separate ways?
God of rainbow, fiery pillar, leading where the eagles soar,
We your people, ours the journey now and ever, now and ever, now and ever more.

Through the flood of **hurting** people, warring factions and despair,
Who will lift the olive branches? Who will light the flame of care?
God of rainbow, fiery pillar, leading where the eagles soar,
We your people, ours the journey now and ever, now and ever, now and ever more.

As we stand a world divided by our own self seeking schemes,
Grant that we, your global village, might envision wider dreams.
God of rainbow, fiery pillar, leading where the eagles soar,
We your people, ours the journey now and ever, now and ever, now and ever more.

-Words and Music by Julian Rush (1985)

[Laura center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness

LVF

Mysterious and Powerful Love, shake our old ways!
Make vivid a new path.
Radicalize our spirits towards compassion.
Alchemize our anger into hope and change.
What joy, what delight, is to be found in co-creating beauty with you, O God,
and with each other.
What wonder is to be found in open-hearted living.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Amen and amen.

[All turn towards choir]

Introit

“Arise, Shine”
Cathedral Choir

Jaebon Hwang

[MS to lectern]

***The Lord’s Prayer**

MS

Let us pray together this Lord’s Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...

*Creator of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.
May your dreams of justice, love, compassion, and
connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourished
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys and
liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power-over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.*

*All praise to you, our comfort and our strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[enfleshed/adpt/lvf]

[All turn towards altar, Jaebon start playing as soon as we say “Amen”]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

LVF

As we continue through this summer season, *in these challenging times*,
let us hold each other carefully as we journey...

Together, let us share these words for peace:

In caring for one another,

may we be untiring

In challenging one another,

may we be respectful,

In sheltering one another,

may we be strong,

In holding one another,

may we be tender.

In the expectations we have of one another,

may we be realistic.

In the songs we sing together,

may we seek harmony.

And in loving one another,

may we be all these things and more.

As we seek to hold faith together, may the peace of God be with you.

And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[MS to lectern]

Hear now these well-known words of the prophet Micah with open hearts...

God has shown you, O mortals, what is good. And what does God require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God.

For this witness of our ancestors...

Thanks be to God!

[Jaebon short transition for LVF to center chancel, meditative but energized]

Prayers with the People

LVF

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

[strong]

God is an invitation.

An allurement.

A disruption.

A chance to do things differently.

Always before us,
God is the possibility of collective change.
Though everyday, ordinary patterns of living
that disguise evil and cover over sins of power,
God makes known what is hidden,
calls us to courage,
and makes us capable of radical solidarity.

We are not left powerless.
Every day there are openings.
Every day a chance to choose what is right.
Every day an opportunity to repattern the world.
[enfleshed/adpt]

Let us now be in silence together.

[2 minutes, then Jaebon transition out of silence, tranquil, reflective]

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of justice and mercy,
we tend to make things so complicated,
creating elaborate belief systems,
while neglecting what matters most.
When we are overwhelmed by
the world's problems, help us return to the fundamentals:

doing justice,
loving mercy,
walking humbly within your Mystery.

Give us courage to choose compassion
when our dominant culture deems empathy as weakness.
Help us recognize practical ways to embody your justice
when tasks overwhelm and seem too large.
Make us people who reflect your heart so clearly
that others experience your inclusive love through us.

[Benjamin Cremer/adapt. ML]

May it ever be so.

May it ever be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen.

[Jaebon transition for trio confident and calming, Jaebon play an Ab major chord with Eb4 on top]

Meditation Anthem “Without You, Without Them” Julien Baker, Phoebe
Bridgers, and Lucy Dacus Tiffany Ho, Laurel Irene, and Molly Pease

[Jaebon transition Michael to pulpit, growing and full]

Sermon *Justice, Mercy, Humility* **ML**

[Jaebon transition as Michael & Laura go behind communion table, full and transitional/connecting]

The Eucharist and Blessings **LVF & ML**

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

LVF: Faithful One, we come to your table hungry for a taste of your kin-dom.

In a world where power and empire come together to hoard and exploit,
we crave the fruits of your Spirit.

We long for kindness.

We dream of peace.

We hope to be people of generosity – sharing and redistributing the resources you intend for the
flourishing of all.

ML: Gathering at your table, we remember the ordinary gifts of heaven among us.

Those that nurture hope when it's hard to find.

That surprise us in destruction's wake.

That bring new life from sites of death.

And sustain our labors of love across generations.

LVF: Since the beginning, you have been building a lineage of love and liberation.

Inviting all who wish to belong.
You call us to turn from the temptations of power and individualism.
To deepen our commitments to building communities of care and justice.

ML: At this Table, we remember how Jesus did just that,
sharing a meal with his companions, his community, his chosen family, before he would be
arrested.

LVF: Filled with love for them, Jesus took bread, blessed it, broke it, gave it to his disciples and
said: “This is my body which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me.”

ML: After the meal, Jesus took the cup, blessed it, and shared it saying:
“This cup that is poured out is the new covenant.”

LVF: And each time we come to this table we honor these words as we remember:
This table is for all, whether you have a lot of faith, etc....

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share
in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice.
You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the
prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of
new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

**[Jaebon play whatever feels right during communion. Generally moving but not too loud
fits well. Try to avoid hymn tunes as they distract Laura. [only hymns that have poor
communion theology!] Wait for the choir and pastors to be settled to end]**

[MS to lectern when all are seated]

Invitation to Generosity

MS

This community is making a tangible difference in the world.
In this place, we strive to live out our values of inclusiveness,
compassion, and generosity.
Each week we gather, as we pray to make the world a better place,
through the generosity of our shared work;
work which helps bend the moral arc of the universe toward justice.
We do the work we do...to heal the world around us.

You can help in this work by giving generously
of your time, your gifts, and your finances.
This morning, we invite you to join us in making an investment
as we work side by side in this community of faith and in our neighborhood and city.

You will find information for giving in your programs and appearing now on your
screens at home. Our Hospitality Team will also come forward to receive your gifts.

Thank you for every expression of generosity.

[Jaebon play C major chord]

Offertory

“More Than Enough”
Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, *Soloist*

Susan LaBarr

[All turn towards altar, Jaebon start playing after a short pause for people to receive the silence after the anthem]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator’s praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[MS to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**

MS

Holy God, as we bring our offerings to you,
we remember those who are vulnerable to suffering and injustice.
Make us people who are gracious in our giving, tender in our mercy and care,
and fierce in our protection of all your beloved people.

May it ever be so.

Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

[Michael & Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

LVF & ML

LVF: Next week, our summer series, *Another Kind of Freedom*, continues with the theme, *The Heart of Service*.

ML: My Book Group will have its first summer pop-up this Tuesday, July 14, 7-8:15pm, on zoom. Men’s Group has their next meeting this coming Wednesday, July 15, 7-9pm here at the church.

LVF: Summer Clothing Drive is ongoing- bring new or gently used summer clothing items to security booth anytime! We’ll share those with our neighbors as part of Food@First on Sunday, Aug. 16.

ML: Two save the dates for you! Sunday, Aug. 9, our LGBTQ+ group here is hosting another Book Launch following the service in Shatto Chapel (**expand**). And our Community Collaborative is hosting a Summer Picnic in the Amanda Scott Gardens on Saturday, Aug. 29th!

LVF: Join us for Coffee Hour today following the Service! Lavender bundles from our Community Gardens are for sale - and your purchase of course - contributes to our gardens.

Words of Blessing

ML

May God bless us with the courage to face discomfort,
that we may grow in compassion for those who suffer.

*May God bless us with restlessness,
so that we are not content with the injustices of this world.*

May God bless us with humble hearts,
to sense and know the Sacred in ourselves and in all.

*May God bless us with deep and unwavering peace,
that it might hold us in the chaos and the quiet alike.*

And may we always remember,
that in the discomfort, and the struggle...
God is present, ever guiding us toward love.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

[Jaebon play F#3s]

Choral Response
Nyamezele

“Bawo Thixo Somandla” Mxolisi Matyila; arr. Sidumo

Laude

“Dear God, show us our wrongdoings that have led to these conflicts so that we may move in the ways of humility.”

[Jaebon start hymn as soon as Laude is done, keep it crisp]

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn for the Journey**
BIG and crisp!

Creative Love

TALLIS' CANON

Creative love, our thanks we give
that this our world, is incomplete,
that struggle greets our will to live,
that work awaits our hands and feet.

That we are not yet fully wise,
that we are in the making still -
as friends who share one enterprise
and strive to blend with nature's will.

What though the future long delay,
and still with faults we daily cope?
It gives us that for which we pray,
a field for toil and faith and hope.

Since what we choose is what we are,
and what we love we yet shall be,
the goal may ever shine afar -
the will to reach it makes us free.

-lyrics by W.W. Hyde

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Recessional, William Mathias (1934-1992)

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

Inside The Music

I've spent a lot of time meditating on justice recently. My reflections have been somewhat fraught. Like with most societally-dependent concepts, I keep coming back to people and relationships. I think that's why the Micah text for this week feels important to me. Justice, mercy, and humility are interwoven into a clear sign that points to the possibility for healthy communities. The music this week grows from this text. Jaebon's "Arise, Shine" introit is a favorite of mine, and I'm excited to get to sing it with her. I have always appreciated the harmonic worlds she inhabits in such a short amount of time. All twelve notes of the chromatic scale are well represented. There are three distinct tonal areas, and the main D tonal area has a persistent duality. To my ear this all speaks to a universality. The light that has come is for all of us and is everywhere around us to be received. Boy Genius' "Without You, Without Them" is a relatively new piece in the a cappella vocal band genre. I am drawn to its lyrical simplicity and lilting melodiousness. These inviting elements set us up to embrace the most important practice of opening to others. They ask us to sit with each other and listen, to be in relationship. Susan LaBarr's setting of Wendell Berry's poem coaxes us into an abundance mindset. Her pastoral setting punctuated by moments of rhythmic and chromatic excitement illuminates the heart of Berry's profound words. Surely the essence of humility lies in realizing that we are sufficient as we are, in this moment. The South African protest anthem "Bawo Thixo Somandla" ends our morning. It is yearning as it is powerful, and asks the question of why we persist in hurting one another. Compassion's desire that all people be given the opportunity to avoid suffering sits at

the heart of justice. For some reason humanity continues to struggle to understand this. Music continues to bring us back to shared experiences where we may learn lessons of togetherness in small, important doses.